

were in the minority” among the “daring spirits, ne'er-do-wells, and adventurers.” Their rewards were not only financial, as “beautiful women from the theater and nightclubs hung around the flying field... unstinting of favors to their current heroes.” Even higher class women might succumb to the rough glamour of aviation. In Paris, where Port Aviation at Juvisy was a similarly popular weekend draw, a diplomat referred sneeringly to a duchess associating with “the scum of the aerodromes.”

Inevitably, as the spectacle of flight became more familiar, it was no longer enough for pilots simply to take off and fly around a field. The public demanded novel stunts and ever more risky maneuvers to stimulate its jaded appetite. French pilot Adolphe Pégoud came to prominence in 1912 as the ace of aerial acrobats. He was the second aviator to “loop the loop,” a stunt that he made part of his

repertoire in a series of lucrative appearances around Europe. That a pilot could fly upside down seemed a sheer miracle to the public and to most aviators, who were barely used to strapping themselves to their seats during a flight. Once it became clear that the public would flock to see

aerobatic stunts, they became *de rigueur* for pilots wanting to make money.

Despite their apparent frivolity, the development of airshow acrobatics represented a significant advance in flying techniques and aircraft control. The loops, tight-banked turns, high-speed dives, and other daredevil maneuvers that began as high-risk entertainment would soon be used to deadly effect by World War I aces in dogfights over Flanders.



PURPLE LADY

Harriet Quimby, the first licensed female pilot in the United States (1911) and the first woman to cross the Channel (1912), is shown here in her trademark purple flight suit.

BELGIAN AVIATRIX

Hélène Dutrieu, a former Belgian champion cyclist, was admired by her contemporaries for her singular feats of aviation. In August 1910 she flew 28 miles (45km) from Ostend to Bruges in 20 minutes, and in December 1911 she smashed the world speed record, flying an average 50mph (80kph) over three hours.

